

5, The Great Expansion Altered the Global Paradigm of Human Civilization

When commenting on early civilizations, people often remark, "*The price of prematurity is premature decay*" (早熟的代价就是早衰). This does not mean that human society undergoes a biological process analogous to human bodies that can be strictly defined as "aging." Rather, it implies that prematurely entering a certain developmental stage might necessitate an excessively protracted wait for the next decisive revolution (*such as a critical breakthrough in technology*). This prolonged waiting period inevitably breeds a multitude of uncertain and certain destructive factors.

The former includes drastic climatic shifts and violent natural disasters—factors entirely beyond human control. As long as the observation timeframe is sufficiently long, the probability of these events occurring approaches exactly 1. The latter encompasses phenomena that inevitably arise due to human activities: the rise of neighboring tribes, the degradation of agricultural conditions, and the exhaustion of natural resources.

A civilized state cannot possibly expect its peripheries to forever remain inhabited by stagnant, unprogressing barbarians, nor can it expect its productive activities to never pose a threat to the natural environment. Therefore, entering a certain stage prematurely, ahead of all other regions, inherently means the probability of that civilization being terminated *before* reaching the next stage is astronomically higher!

For the inhabitants of Mesopotamia, Egypt, and the Indus Valley, the great rivers amidst the deserts were indeed a comfortable cradle. But once the era shifted, this relatively closed environment rapidly mutated into a cage! It is akin to a fundamental truth: **An infant cannot remain in a cradle for an entire lifetime.**

The decisive technological revolution occurred in tools. Precisely speaking, the emergence and maturation of metal smelting technology enabled the manufacture and universalization of bronze and iron tools. **This process eternally altered the face of the human world.**

Prior to this, humanity's capacity to transform nature was exceedingly finite. The civilized world existed merely as isolated pockets in a few regions boasting superior and stable agricultural conditions, entirely segregated by vast wildernesses. Following this revolution, civilization rapidly conquered those savage hinterlands. New cities and states were erected in newly developed territories. This phenomenon occurred universally across the Eurasian landmass, and those ethnic groups that seized the initiative during this revolution would later become renowned across the globe as the glorious architects of **classical empires**.

As for the specific forms these revolutionary tools and technologies took when applied in different regions, and the exact modalities through which the "Great Conquest" of the final millennium BC unfolded... (*Of course, this is not to say **The Great Expansion** only commenced in 1000 BC. Long before that, the Shang Dynasty in China had already undertaken massive expansions, the Mycenaeans [迈锡尼人] had established colonies in Anatolia, and the Aryans [雅利安人] had begun their migrations. However, it was during the final millennium BC that this process became phenomenally conspicuous.*)

This process inevitably diverged because people made adaptations tailored to their specific geographical environments (因地制宜).

In the Indian subcontinent, the paramount mission for the invading Aryans was the eradication of the forests. For members of a civilization living in the tropics, battling the jungle was indeed a crucial component of ancient life. Surviving texts describe this process with vivid imagination. For example, the *Shatapatha Brahmana* (百道梵书) claims that Agni (阿耆尼), the god of fire, incinerated the dense forests of the Ganges River basin, thereby enabling the Aryans to inhabit the area.

In antiquity, an absolutely critical task before reclaiming wasteland was setting fires. First, to burn away the surface vegetation; second, to utilize metal agricultural tools to eradicate the seeds of plants detrimental to agriculture that might still survive in the soil. For regions with terrifyingly dense vegetation, fire was even more indispensable. The early Mahajanapadas (早期列国 / the great realms) in India still operated as massive **communities** (社群), ruled by clans, and only began transitioning toward monarchies in the 6th century BC. Because the region possesses a tropical monsoon climate, the capacity of the government was severely shackled by the natural environment; forests and mountainous terrains were chronically ungovernable. Therefore, the **community** would persist as a fundamental unit of political life in India for a remarkably long time.

For another branch of Aryans who migrated into Iran, their paramount mission was battling water scarcity and resolving the irrigation problem on the Iranian plateau. During the final millennium BC, technological advancements yielded magnificent achievements, most notably the *Qanat* systems (坎儿井). This allowed civilization to shatter its confinement to Elam in southwestern Iran and proliferate across the entire Iranian plateau!

During the reign of the Achaemenid Empire, imperial rulers actively encouraged the construction and maintenance of Qanats. Needless to say, constructing such colossal hydraulic engineering projects would have been utterly unimaginable without sophisticated metal tools. The new regimes established by the Aryans in Iran were monarchies. At that time, regimes across the Near East were universally monarchical. Whether driven by the necessity to compete with rival regimes or the imperative to organize massive engineering construction, the choice of monarchy was obviously an inevitability!

For the Greeks and Phoenicians (腓尼基人) dwelling along the coasts of the Aegean and the Eastern Mediterranean, the most critical technology for colonial expansion was undoubtedly navigation. Benefiting from advancements in maritime technology, the Greeks and Phoenicians established a vast network of colonies along the shores of the Mediterranean and the Black Sea. Many remain renowned to this day, such as Tripoli (的黎波里) and Marseille (马赛).

Some of these would subsequently evolve into regional hegemons, such as Carthage (迦太基). Others would eventually become the capitals of empires, such as Byzantium! These colonial cities were heavily influenced by their mother states and adopted certain city-state political forms prevalent on the Greek peninsula. They might also experience institutional mutations similar to those in the Greek homeland. Overall, however, compared to the **Great Expansions** occurring in other regions during the same period, the democratic elements here were consistently more abundant.

In China, the challenges our ancestors faced during their expansion were highly diverse: when slash-and-burn clearing was needed, they burned the wilderness; in waterlogged regions, they drained the lands; and when water was scarce, they dammed rivers for irrigation.

Although during **Late Imperial China**, the connotation of "water conservancy" (水利) had mutated into *"benefiting the monarch while devastating the myriad people,"* in China's foundational stage, these hydraulic engineering projects were undeniably worthy of immense praise and indeed achieved extraordinary feats.

Unlike the aforementioned three regions, China—as a **primary civilization** (原生文明)—forged a monarchical state with commanding superiority in the middle and lower reaches of the Yellow River very early on, following prolonged confrontations and amalgamations among various *Fangguo* (方国 / early chiefdoms or proto-states). Even if it remains unclear which specific archaeological site the Xia Dynasty (夏朝) corresponds to, or whether it has been discovered at all, the existence of the Shang Dynasty (商朝) is glaringly obvious and beyond any doubt.

Judging by textual and archaeological data, the Shang Dynasty unequivocally established an overwhelming superiority over peripheral regimes in Northern China, truly living up to its self-designation as the "Great Settlement Shang" (大邑商). Furthermore, it was genuinely expanding right up until the eve of its demise! *(To be honest, people today only possess a relatively clear understanding of the mid-to-late history of the Shang Dynasty; after all, mature writing did not exist the moment the Shang was established. But at least during the periods we do understand, the military campaigns of the Shang kings were absolutely ceaseless).*

The Zhou Dynasty (周朝), which superseded the Shang, adopted a strategy that history proved to be phenomenally successful. Bolstered by the patriarchal clan system (血缘宗法制), it dispatched royal family members and trusted aristocrats to conduct eastward colonization activities. They established vassal states (诸侯国) one after another, which fiercely anchored themselves within fortified cities surrounded by "barbarians."

This behavior exhibited one exceptionally distinct characteristic: For two and a half centuries, the Zhou royal court basically maintained leadership over these expansionist activities and successfully controlled the vassals it had "enfeoffed" (分封). *(I use quotation marks here because the territories these vassals eventually possessed originally did not belong to the Son of Heaven at all).*

This massive expansion—conducted under the centralized command of a supreme regime—ensured that even after the Zhou Emperor lost real power, the increasingly independent regimes across the vast network conquered by the Western Zhou still maintained a remarkably high degree of shared cultural identity.

Furthermore, because the history from the birth of China's **early states** to the late stage of **The Great Expansion** (the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods) was excessively protracted—spanning between 15 to 20 centuries—the dominant regimes (*namely, those later deemed orthodox: Xia, Shang, and Zhou*) were able to continuously expand their sphere of rule. *(Though in eras predating the late Shang, it is difficult to definitively assert that administrative expansion occurred based solely on the cultural uniformity of unearthed artifacts; it might merely have been shifts in spheres of influence caused by dependency and alliances).* Consequently, the tribal forces in Northern China were severely and systematically pulverized!

This is where the situation becomes fascinating. Although China was born as a **primary civilization**—and emerged relatively late compared to its peers—those peers were left behind by the era. Yet, in the massive colonial expansions preceding the classical era, China found itself

competing on the exact same stage as a group of "junior" secondary civilizations, and its seniority was actually the oldest among them!

"The Great Expansion" is a monumental watershed in human civilization. Those ancient civilizations—whose histories were considered profoundly ancient even back then—inevitably marched toward decay as long as they failed to participate in this specific historical process.

For the Egyptians and the inhabitants of the Indus Valley and Mesopotamia, the deserts that once besieged their rivers had now mutated into cages restricting them! Acquiring mineral resources was exceedingly difficult, and due to the scarcity of vegetation, even securing fuel for large-scale metal smelting became a severe crisis. Although the former territories of these Old World veterans eventually became parts of new empires (*though the Indus Valley Civilization simply vanished on its own*), one clearly cannot attribute this failure merely to foreign invasions.

This is evident because the plight of their peers in the New World was obviously even bleaker! The Americas lacked many domesticated animals useful to humans, and metal tools were only used sporadically. For the inhabitants of the Valley of Mexico and the Maya, the moment environmental shifts exceeded their highly limited regulatory capacities, unsolvable societal crises erupted!

Whether it was the collapse of "Classic Teotihuacan" or the "Classic Maya"—(*I use quotation marks to emphasize that pre-Columbian America was relatively primitive, and the academic nomenclature here operates on a different standard than Old World civilizations; "Classic Maya" here absolutely does not refer to the classical empire stage of Mayan civilization. Although the end of the Mayan Classic period also featured urban decay and the construction of heavily fortified new cities—which are characteristic of **Late Antiquity**—the post-Classic Mayan period was obviously light-years away from **feudalization***)—their declines are exceedingly difficult to explain as the result of invasions by powerful external enemies. In the ancient regions of Mexico and Mesoamerica—civilizational zones far more isolated than the Old World—there probably weren't that many covetous predators eyeing them anyway.

The ethnic groups that successfully executed this expansion would go on to establish a batch of the most prestigious **classical empires** in human history, empires whose glory is still deeply reminisced by descendants thousands of years later.

This transformation was by no means accidental. People can comprehend this through three specific dimensions.

5, 大扩张改变了人类文明的格局

人们在评论早期文明的时候经常会说“早熟的代价就是早衰”，这不是说人类社会具有人类身体这样能够被定义为“衰老”的过程，而是说过早地进入某一发展阶段可能导致为了等到下一次决定性的变革（比如某种关键技术）需要的时间过长，这就产生了一些不确定的以及确定的破坏因素。前者包括大幅的气候变化，剧烈的自然灾害这样人力完全不可控的因素，只要观察的时间足够长，这些事件发生的概率就会越来越接近1。后者包括临近族群的兴起，农业条件的恶化，自然资源耗尽这样由于人类活动而必然会出现的现象。一个文明国家不能指望自己周边永远都是从不进步的蛮族，不能指望生产活动对于自然环境永远不构成威胁。因此先于其他各地过早进入某一阶段也就意味着在进入下一阶段之前文明被终止的概率高了很多。对于美索不达米亚，埃及和印度河的居民来说，沙漠中的大河确实是一片舒适的摇篮，但是一旦时代发生变化，这种相对封闭的环境就会迅速转变为囚笼，好比婴儿不可能一辈子都待在摇篮里。

决定性的技术变革出现在工具上，确切地说是金属冶炼技术的出现和成熟使得青铜和铁制工具被制造出来并走向普及，这个过程永远改变了人类世界的面貌。在此之前，人类对于自然的改造能力极其有

限，文明世界只存在于被蛮荒之地分割开的，个别农业自然条件优越且稳定的地区。在此之后，文明得以快速征服那些蛮荒之地，新的城市和国家在被开发的地区建立起来，这种现象普遍出现在欧亚大陆，那些在变革中先机占尽的族群，日后都将以古典帝国缔造者的光辉形象而闻名世间。至于这些革命性的工具和技术在不同的地方具体以什么样的形式被应用，公元前最后一个千纪的“大征服”以什么模式展开（当然，这不是说大扩张是从公元前 1000 年才开始的，早在此前商朝就进行了大幅扩张，迈锡尼人（Mycenae）在安纳托利亚就建立了殖民地，雅利安人也开始迁徙。不过在公元前最后一个千纪这个过程才变得极为显著）

这个过程必然会由于人们因地制宜地选择而有不同。在印度次大陆，侵入的雅利安人最大的任务在于消灭森林，对于生活在热带的文明成员来说，与森林进行斗争的确是古代生活的一个重要内容。流传下来的文献以一种生动的想象描述了这一过程，例如《百道梵书》中声称是火神阿耆尼（Agni）焚烧了恒河流域的茂密森林，使得雅利安人能够居住此处。在古代开垦荒地前的一个极为重要的工作便是放火，首先要烧掉地表的植物，其次用金属质的农具去除掉土中仍然可能残存的对于农业来说属于有害植物的种子，对于植被极其茂密的地区火就更加必不可少。印度的早期列国尚属于庞大的社群，由氏族进行统治，在公元前六世纪开始向君主国转变。作为位于热带季风气候的地区，政府的能力受到自然环境的限制，森林和山地长期难以管辖，因此社群会长期以政治生活一个基本单位在印度存在。

对于另一支进入伊朗的雅利安人来说，他们最大的使命是跟缺水进行斗争，解决伊朗高原的灌溉问题。在公元前的最后五千年，技术进步带来了辉煌的成就，例如坎儿井，这帮助文明不再局限于伊朗西南部的埃兰，而是在整个伊朗高原扩散。在阿契美尼德王朝统治时期，帝国统治者鼓励坎儿井的建设和维护。而自不必说，能够建设这样大型的水利工程如果没有精湛的金属工具完全是不可想象的。在伊朗的雅利安人所建立的新政权属于君主国，当时近东亚洲地区的政权普遍都是君主制国家，出于与其他政权竞争的需要也好，工程建设的需要也罢，选择君主制显然有必然性。

对于爱琴海以及东地中海沿岸的希腊人和腓尼基人来说，想要殖民扩张最重要的技术莫过于航海。得益于航海技术的发展，希腊人和腓尼基人在地中海和黑海沿岸建立了广大的殖民地，很多至今仍然闻名遐迩，例如的黎波里、马赛。有的日后发展成为地区强国，比如迦太基。还有的日后将成为帝国的首都，比如拜占庭。这些殖民城市会受到母邦的影响，采取希腊半岛存在的某种城邦政治形式，也可能发生像希腊本土一样的体制变动，不过总的来说比起同时期其他地区的大扩张这里的民主成分总是要多一些。

在中国，先民们扩张面临的挑战是多样的，该烧荒的时候需要烧荒，水多的地方要排水，缺水的时候要拦水灌溉。虽然说在中华帝国晚期水利这两个字的内涵已经变成了“利君主而害万民”，但是至少在中国的创始阶段水利工程还是值得受到极大称赞的，并且确实成就非凡。不同于之前所述的三地，中国作为原生文明经过方国之间的长期对抗和融合，在黄河中下游地区很早就形成了具有显著优势的王权国家。哪怕夏朝具体对应哪个遗址，到底有没有发现尚且还不清楚，但是商朝的存在是显而易见，不用怀疑的。从文献和考古资料来看，商朝显然在中国北方建立起了对周边政权压倒性的优势，不愧对自己“大邑商”的称呼，并且是真的直到临近灭亡的时候都在扩张（不过说实在的人们现在只是对商朝后期甚至是晚期的历史比较清楚，毕竟不是商朝刚建立的时候就有了成熟文字，至少在人们比较了解的时期，商王的军事行动是持续不断的）。

取代商朝的周朝采取了一种被历史证明极为成功的策略，以血缘宗法制为支撑派出王室成员及亲信贵族进行东向殖民活动，建立起一个又一个依托城市而在“野蛮人”的包围中顽强立足的诸侯国。这一行为展现出了一个非常明显的特征，那就是周王室在长达两个半世纪的时间里基本维持了对这种扩张活动的领导权力，基本能控制自己“分封”（之所以打引号是因为这些诸侯日后拥有的领土原本常常并非天子所有）出去的诸侯。这种在一个最高政权指挥下进行的大扩张令即使在周天子丧失权力之后，西周所征服的广大土地所编织的网络上各个日渐独立的政权仍然能有程度比较高的共有的文化认同。而且由于中国早期国家诞生到大扩张后期（春秋战国）的历史过于漫长，在 15 至 20 个世纪之间，优势政权（也就是被后来认为正统的夏商周）能够持续通过扩大统治范围（不过在比晚商更早的年代，仅仅凭出土器物在文化上的一致性也难以笃定地说发生了行政上的扩张，也可能只是依附和结盟导致的势力范围变动）中国北方地区的部族势力已经被严重削弱了。这就是事情有趣之处，中国虽然作为原生文明诞生，并且跟同类出现算晚，但是这些同类却被时代甩在身后。然而在古典时代前一阶段的大范围殖民扩张中，中国和一群次生文明这样的“后辈”同台竞技，它的资历反而是最老的。

“大扩张”是人类文明的一个重要的分水岭，那些作为即使在当时来看历史都极为悠久的古代文明，只要没有参与这个历史进程都走向了衰亡。对于埃及人，印度河流域和美索不达米亚的居民来说，包围河流的荒漠现在成为限制他们自己的囚笼，矿产资源获取不容易，甚至因为植被匮乏连大规模金属冶炼的燃料都会成为问题。虽然这些旧大陆的老前辈曾经的领土都成为新帝国的一部分（不过印度河文明是自己消失的），但是人们显然不能将这种失败认为是外敌入侵的结果。因为新大陆的同行们显然处境更为暗淡，这里缺少不少对人类有用的驯化动物，金属工具只是零星地使用。对于墨西哥谷地和玛雅的居民来说，一旦环境变化超过他们十分有限的调节能力，无法解决的社会危机就会出现。无论是“古典特奥蒂瓦坎”还是“古典玛雅”（之所以打引号是想强调前哥伦布时期的美洲比较原始，学界的一些称呼的标准与旧大陆文明并不相同，这里的古典玛雅并非指玛雅文明的古典帝国时期。尽管玛雅古典时期结束时也有城市衰退，新建城市重视军事防御这样属于古典晚期的特征，但是玛雅的后古典时期显然和封建化相去甚远）的衰落，都很难解释为外部的强力敌人入侵的结果，在墨西哥和中美洲这一片人类古代相对于旧大陆封闭得多的文明区域，大概本身也没有那么多虎视眈眈的觊觎者。成功扩张的民族将建立一批人类历史上最富声望，即使在千百年后仍然被后人怀念的古典帝国，这一变化绝非偶然，人们可以从三个方面理解这一点。